

PATNA
Digital Community Platform
Concept Note
Professional African Technical Network Advisory (PATNA) Initiative

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Concept Note – PATNA Digital Community Platform
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1. Background and Problem Statement

African countries are navigating increasingly complex climate and energy transitions, operating under constrained fiscal space, fragmented institutions, and rapidly evolving global rules. Despite growing engagement in international climate processes – from the IMO to the UNFCCC – many decisions affecting African economies are still made with limited coordination, incomplete information, and weak institutional continuity.

PATNA was established to address this gap. Initially focused on maritime decarbonisation, PATNA has evolved into an African-led platform supporting inclusive energy transition and climate action, grounded in evidence, coordination, and long-term institutional learning.

The challenge is digital infrastructure. PATNA's current website functions primarily as an information repository. It does not enable:

- Structured onboarding and participation across cohorts
- Sustained coordination and collaboration between members
- Systematic reuse of accumulated knowledge and insights
- Scalable delivery of PATNA's decision-intelligence role

This concept note presents the design of a purpose-built digital community platform that reflects how PATNA actually works: as a coordinator, synthesiser, and enabler of African-centred decision-making.

2. What We Are Building

The PATNA Digital Community Platform is a structured, governed community environment designed for a curated membership of African technical experts, policymakers, academics, industry professionals, and civil society actors. It is not a generic social network or document repository. It is a working environment that reflects PATNA's governance model and supports real decision-making processes.

2.1 Core Modules

Module	Description
Member Dashboard	Personalised home view showing spaces, discussions, events, applications, and community activity scoped to the user's cohort role and permissions.
Cohort Spaces	Structured discussion environments for each PATNA cohort (Policy, Academic, Industry, Civil Society) and sub-groups (SIDS, LDCs, oil-producing states, working groups).
Member Directory	Searchable, filter-driven directory of all community members with profile visibility

lity controls, expertise tagging, and direct contact (subject to member preferences).

Events

A full calendar view of internal, PATNA-organised, and external international events – with RSVP, registration tracking, and linked outputs for past events.

Insights Hub

A unified knowledge repository housing blogs, technical briefs, reports, and event outputs – tagged by theme, cohort relevance, geography, and process.

Applications

Structured onboarding workflow from expression of interest through interview to approval. Cohort leads can review and recommend; admin retains approval authority.

PATNA Assistant (Phase 2)

A context-aware AI assistant grounded in PATNA's knowledge base and governed by user-level access policies. Surfaces relevant content, members, and insights on demand.

2.2 Design Principles

- Cohort-based identity – members belong to one or more cohorts and participate within their permitted spaces
- Role-based permissions – clear distinction between members, cohort leads, moderators, and administrators
- Tag-driven structure – cross-cutting collaboration across constituencies (SIDS, LDCs, oil-producing states)
- Human-first – AI introduced only after governance and data foundations are in place
- Access-scoped intelligence – all AI features respect the same permission boundaries as the human-facing platform

3. Platform Governance

The platform is structured around PATNA's existing governance model. Four user roles are supported:

Role

Key Responsibilities

Access Level

Administrator

Platform governance, user management, final application approval

Full access across all cohorts and tools

Cohort Lead

Space moderation, application review and recommendation, member coordination

Full access within assigned cohort(s); read access to cross-cohort Insights

Member

Discussion participation, content engagement, profile management

Access to own cohort space(s) and public community features

Applicant

Expression of interest, interview, profile completion

No community access until approved

4. The PATNA Assistant – AI Decision Support

The PATNA Assistant is a context-aware AI interface integrated into the member dashboard. Unlike general-purpose AI tools, it is:

- Grounded exclusively in PATNA-approved content – discussions, Insights, member profiles, events, and working group materials
- Access-scoped – it surfaces only information the logged-in user is permitted to view. A Policy Cohort member cannot surface content from spaces they do not belong to.
- Transparent – users can inspect exactly what data sources the as

assistant can and cannot access at any time via an in-panel access log

- Non-generative in sensitive contexts – the assistant does not invent positions, generate documents, or answer questions outside its grounded knowledge base

The PATNA Assistant is not a chatbot. It is a structured retrieval interface designed to help members find, connect, and synthesise knowledge that already exists within the community – faster and more accurately than manual search.

Phase 2 development will introduce Retrieval-Augmented Generation (RAG) architecture, using PATNA's indexed knowledge base as the source of truth for all responses. Role-based access policies are enforced at the retrieval layer, not just at the UI layer.

5. Phased Delivery

Phase 1 – Platform MVP (Month 1)

- Redesigned public website
- Unified Insights publishing system
- Community onboarding workflow (expression of interest → interview → approval)
- Member profiles, cohort assignment, expertise tagging
- Community spaces with moderated discussions
- Role-based governance tools

Outcome: A fully functional platform enabling community engagement and structured knowledge sharing.

Phase 2 – AI Integration (Month 2)

- Structuring and indexing of all PATNA knowledge assets
- RAG-based AI assistant integration
- Role-aware retrieval with access policy enforcement
- Testing, evaluation, and documentation

Outcome: An AI-augmented platform that supports sense-making and decision coordination – without replacing human judgement.

6. Budget Summary

Cost Category

Phase 1 (€)

Phase 2 (€)

Total (€)

Software Engineering

2,000,000

2,000,000

4,000,000

UX/UI Design

1,200,000

500,000

1,700,000

Product & Technical Leadership

2,000,000

1,800,000

3,800,000

AI / Infrastructure Setup & Testing

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700,000

700,000

Contingency & Integration Buffer

800,000

1,000,000

1,800,000
Total
6,000,000
6,000,000
12,000,000

7. Expected Outcomes

By the end of the project, PATNA will have:

- A modern digital presence aligned with its evolving strategic mandate
- A structured, governed community platform with cohort-based identity and role-based permissions
- A unified Knowledge & Insights Hub supporting real decision processes
- A future-ready data foundation for AI-enabled decision support
- Improved engagement with members, partners, and funders
- Stronger institutional memory and continuity across the network

This project positions PATNA not as a network or repository, but as a living decision-intelligence system capable of supporting Africa's energy transition and climate action over time.

8. Conclusion

The PATNA Digital Community Platform is a modest, time-bound investment with significant strategic returns. It transforms PATNA's digital infrastructure from a passive repository into an active coordination and intelligence environment – one that reflects the complexity of PATNA's work and the expertise of its members.

Built locally with full institutional ownership, the platform creates a durable foundation for PATNA's next phase of growth, while demonstrating to funders and partners that PATNA is building systems – not just producing documents.

Total Investment: ~~¥~~12,000,000 (approx. USD 7,500–8,000) across two phases.

Timeline: 8 weeks from design to deployment.

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